

content as well—and the only hope we have of making that happen is if AI can help us.”

And beyond

Everyone is trying to keep abreast of what the tech majors like Nvidia, Meta, and Microsoft are doing about the metaverse. But to understand the future of the technology, we should perhaps stop and look outside the tech world, at how everyone else is preparing for it.

According to a report in The Guardian, McDonald’s recently filed ten trademark applications, including one for a virtual restaurant. Also, Walmart, Samsung, and PricewaterhouseCoopers are moving ahead with plans to operate in the metaverse.

There is excitement in the football world too, as English Premier League champions Manchester City recently partnered with Sony to develop digital fan experiences. According to the announcement, “The aim of this collaboration is to create a global online fan community where fans can interact with the club and each other within an online ‘metaverse’ which will be a virtual recreation of the Etihad Stadium.” They might even be able to watch matches in the metaverse.

According to Interpol’s recent Global Crime Trend report, cyber-crimes are one of the world’s leading crime threats, and are projected to increase more than other crimes in future. The report says that crime has increasingly moved online as the pace of digitalisation has increased. “Criminals are sophisticated and professional in very quickly adapting to any new technological tool that is available to commit crime,” Interpol Secretary-General Jürgen Stock told the BBC in a recent interview. Not to be left in the dark, Interpol is increasingly using its metaverse, which it launched last October, to help officers understand



Live-streaming using holograms, demonstrated at CES 2023 (Courtesy: CES/Brian Kong)

the nature of crimes in the virtual world and how they can tackle these.

The Hermès Handbag Case, which sounds so much like the title of a Hercule Poirot mystery, is one that mightily interested policy makers in recent times. Luxury goods brand Hermès sued Mason Rothschild for creating NFTs called MetaBirkins using virtual furry interpretations of their Birkin series of handbags, without their permission. They argued that people would think the NFTs were affiliated with the brand. “I’m not creating or selling fake Birkin bags. I’m creating art works that depict imaginary, fur-covered Birkin bags. The fact that I sell the art using NFTs doesn’t change the fact that it’s art,” argued Rothschild, adding that he had put in required disclaimers about not being associated with the brand.

However, as explained in a World Economic Forum report, “Many fashion brands are showing interest in the metaverse, where they could sell digital clothing and accessories for avatars. Having the ability to control their designs and brands, and to enforce their intellectual property, will be critical to

how profitable the metaverse could prove for them.” In February this year, the jury ordered Rothschild to pay US\$133,000 in damages to Hermès, determining that he did, in fact, profit off Hermès’ goodwill by producing NFTs based on the design house’s Birkin bags. This case has set a precedent as to how trademark laws are likely to be applied to digital assets.

There is invariably a lot of stuff going on related to the metaverse—in and outside the tech world. According to a Gartner strategic planning assumption, by 2027 over 40% of large organisations worldwide will be using a combination of Web3, spatial computing, and digital twins in metaverse based projects aimed at increasing revenue. “The metaverse seems more hype than reality right now, so now is exactly the time to start to take advantage of it,” says Gartner, on their website.

Right now, the metaverse is something that you cannot ignore. At the same time, experts suggest moving with caution, because it is still not clear which metaverse-specific technologies and investments will have long-term impact and returns. **EFY**